



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with MN

Anonymous (MN)

16th November 2018

Location of interview: Queen's University Belfast

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Sam Manning

Warning this transcript contains reference to sexual abuse

MN was sent to Thorndale House (the Salvation Army's mother and baby institution in Belfast) during the 1960s when she became pregnant, aged 16. The father was her 16 year-old boyfriend. She expressed her very unpleasant memories about Thorndale. This included recalling being marched across north Belfast to the local Salvation Army Citadel for Sunday worship where, she feels, the unmarried mothers from Thorndale were publically shamed in front of the congregation. MN describes a harsh regime with a routine of demanding physical labour for heavily pregnant girls and women. In her case, this included being rushed back to manual labour just days after giving birth with negative health consequences. MN also recalled there being no sympathy for the pregnant victims of sexual abuse that she encountered in Thorndale. She also describes a cold routine surrounding the handing over of babies for adoption. MN's testimony also includes discussion of sexual abuse she experienced as a victim of her boyfriend's father, who employed a religiously respectable persona to inflict negative consequences on MN's life in several respects.

The transcript has been edited to remove any identifying information about the interviewee, family members etc. Where information has been redacted this is indicated by **.

MN: And any names that I mention will be...

OD: I'll take any names out, any identifiers. Perfect, so we are recording now.

MN: Okay.

OD: For the purposes just of the tape, my name is Olivia Dee and I am ... arranging the microphone. I am the oral historian on the Northern Ireland Mother and Babies and Magdalene Laundries Project. We're here in my office in Queen's University Belfast. It's the fifteenth...

MN: sixteenth.

OD: It's the sixteenth, well done, of November 2018. I'm here with an interviewee who is going to talk to me about her experience and we'll just start by reassuring you as you've said ... that you have, kind of, read through the forms, but that if we mention any names etc. we will be taking those out. So there's no, kind of, issue there. We can remove anything that you're worried might in any way point towards, kind of ...

MN: Somebody else.

OD: Exactly. So that you feel comfortable and happy with being anonymous.

MN: Okay.

OD: So we have had a little discussion beforehand about the way that we're going to do this, so if you're happy to I can ask you some questions and then you can just tell me what you feel happy or comfortable talking about?

MN: That's alright.

OD: Perfect. So can you tell me a little bit about what connects you to the mother and baby homes? Which home were you in etc.?

MN: I was in Thorndale House in *date in the 1960s*. I became pregnant in *a date a few months earlier* when I was sixteen and I had a baby in Thorndale House in *month and year redacted*. It was a very shameful thing to become pregnant at that time and I was, my family were... hid me, or I was kept hidden, or made to stay hidden. In the last few months, I went into Thorndale House prior to the birth. I can't remember how long. I think about six weeks, I think. And I, maybe longer, and before that I could only go out at night, when it was dark, when nobody would see me. So during the day I just stayed in the house and then I went there and that was the Salvation Army. I had no idea what to expect. Before, actually before all that when I first became pregnant, I was taken to a backstreet abortionist, to a doctor. I can't remember his name. He ... it was a disgustingly dirty surgery in what I presumed to have been his house. He was a horrible person, for a sixteen-year-old anyway. He scared the life out of me.

OD: Of course.

MN: And he offered to perform an abortion for ... and I don't know how much money because I wasn't going to be paying for it. And actually the baby's father's father arranged that Mummy would take me there. He drove us there. We talked to the doctor. He explained that what he would do, that he would perform an abortion and that if I had extensive bleeding I would have to go to hospital and I was not to say where or what had happened. And we left with an

arrangement to come back and have that done. And I went home and I was so frightened of the doctor, of the place, of the examination that he had just given me, that I couldn't go through with it. And I, so then I was told the only alternative then was to have the baby adopted. This is what I was told. I wasn't given a choice with my family or the baby's father's family. Him nor I, neither of us were given a choice. We were both very young. He actually wasn't even seventeen and I was just seventeen. And the, so the option then was that his father said that I could go, or would make arrangements for me to go, to Thorndale House. And I went there for a time and I'm not sure how long. It could have been three months before the birth. I really can't remember how long before the birth. And I went there, we didn't, we got out, you could go out occasionally for a walk. Thorndale House was in a part of Belfast that I wasn't familiar with.

OD: Antrim Road.

MN: Yeah, I was not familiar with it at all. And nobody would know me. So I, we were allowed to go out occasionally. My mother and the baby's grandad, as I say, came and took me out for maybe one day a week or one afternoon a week. And that's when the photographs were taken.¹ But before she was born, I can remember... No, it wasn't before, it was after she was born, actually when I got out I phoned Mummy and asked her could I please keep my baby? And she just said "and where do you think you're going to stay?" [MN became tearful at this point] I didn't have anywhere to stay, I didn't have a job, I didn't have any way of keeping the baby. My father supported me and he would have allowed to come home, but my mother wouldn't. And his mother, his father [meaning her boyfriend's parents] wouldn't either, I tend to think? Well after my mother died,

¹ MN has some photographs at this time which she brought to the interview.

Daddy told me that it was more his influence [boyfriend's father], that Mummy might have let me come home. But she was influenced not to and she might not have let me home.

OD: Who do you think she was influenced by?

MN: By my boyfriend's father.

OD: Right.

MN: And it was him who organised everything to do with going into Thorndale House. When we were in there, the regime was fairly horrible now when I think about it. At the time I just accepted whatever because I was a bad girl. I had been very, very bad and I needed to be punished. So I just accepted it. It was punishment and I deserved it and that was that. I had... when we were there and we were pregnant, life was easier for the pregnant mothers than it was for the mothers who had already had their babies. And we were segregated from them. We were kept separate. We were all marched to the Citadel, somewhere about the Antrim Road, I'm not sure where, by the staff on a Sunday to church.² And we were taken there and marched in. We didn't have a choice whether we went or not, we were just taken. And I think it was to demonstrate how bad we were and how, you know, we needed to look for forgiveness and atone for our sins. I think that was really why we were taken. And it also showed everybody else in the Citadel, you know, as an example. So an example was very much made of us, both before and after our babies were born. And in the most part, we were all very young girls. As I say, before the baby was born the treatment was physically, physically I suppose, all through the... well, no physically before the

² This is most likely to have been the Salvation Army Citadel on York Street, which was a 15 minute walk.

baby was born the treatment was reasonable. We were very much looked down upon, very much frowned upon and we had, there was, and I'm going to say her name, Sergeant *name redacted*, she was one of the people who was there. And I actually, we had cleaning duties to do, and I had to clean her room. That was part of my job. We had to clean corridors, we had to do that on your hands and knees.

OD: At seven months pregnant?

MN: Right up to nine months pregnant, right up till our babies were born. That was done. We had ... and then there was no antenatal, there was nothing to tell you what was going to happen. I hadn't a clue. I got up one night and went to the bathroom because I felt I needed to go to the toilet and my waters burst, broke. And I then called somebody. And there was one nice girl, and I can't remember her name, who was in the Salvation Army and she came and took me to the maternity unit. Because everything was in Thorndale House.

OD: Oh really.

MN: The maternity unit, they had their own maternity unit so I was taken there. And I gave birth there. I was then, we then stayed in the maternity unit for, I don't know, a few days, possibly a week. I can't remember. And then after that we were then sent to sleep in a different part of the house with all the girls who'd had their babies. And we got a different job. And my job, a week after my baby was born, was in their laundry, which was the, you know, according to the girls that I then met, was one of the worst places to be. The laundry was, if you've watched like Downton Abbey or any of those programmes, it was very much a Victorian laundry. It had huge boilers that were, I think they were coal-fired and they heated water. And then all the sheets, and all the nappies, and all

the things from the maternity unit as well as the other sheets all come down and they had to be sluiced and cleaned. And then in one massive, big tub and then transferred to another one and washed again. And this was all done by hand, so I mean your hands were, it was very, very sore on your hands. And then washed, and no washing machines, all just washed by hand, and then put through wringers and hung out if it was dry, and otherwise hung inside. So you were working ... it was a bit like a Chinese laundry. I've never been in a Chinese laundry, but just you see it was all steam and hot and very, very hard work.³

OD: So this was a week after giving birth?

MN: Yes, from then. And a short time after that, I wasn't there very long, and again I can't remember how long because it's so long ago and I have not talked about this aspect of it, but I have thought about it from when I spoke to you [in a phone call before this interview]. It was ... I started to bleed heavily and I haemorrhaged and I had to go back to their maternity unit. I was taken back to it. And then after that I wasn't put back in the laundry because I was only a tiny wee thing and I wasn't fit for that sort of heavy work. Not that anybody was. Nobody should have been doing that.

OD: Especially a week after that.

MN: We were treated quite horribly by most of the staff. I dare to say nearly all of the staff. We were in dormitories. We were all made to breastfeed our babies. We didn't have an option. We were forced to breastfeed our babies with the knowledge that in six weeks we were going to give these babies away. That was

³ The laundry was for Thorndale House use only. It does not appear to have operated on a commercial basis.

horrible. That was mental torture. And many of us had problems with sore breasts and whatever, as always is the case whenever you start to breastfeed. And we were not allowed to wear a bra in bed, which would have helped to support our breasts and made it a wee bit easier. If you tried to slip into bed with a bra on, then they would march round and look and see and if you had a bra on, it had to be taken off.

OD: Why?

MN: We don't know why. I think it was just to hurt us, to make life more difficult than it already was. It was sadistic, it was cruel and it was also... we were, we had to get up at, I think it was about five in the morning, five or six maybe. Because we had to feed at six. So we had to get up maybe half-five, around that. And we had to feed again, we had to feed at night, at ten or after it. So we would be going to bed quite late and getting up very early. And you had to get up and be dressed and up to the maternity wing to feed your baby for six o'clock. And sometimes we would try and sleep in our clothes if possible so that you didn't have to quickly get dressed in the morning. That again wasn't allowed. They would come in and be very sharp about, you know, 'get up! Get out! Get up and feed your babies!' We were treated, we were treated badly when you look at it now, we were treated very badly. But we all accepted it. And I can remember one girl who was fourteen who, this was her second baby, and her baby's father was her father and he had raped her twice. Well, he'd raped her more than twice, but twice it had resulted in a pregnancy. And we all felt so sorry for her. And they were, they were lovely girls there. They weren't bad girls, they weren't. You know, they were all lovely girls and we were all treated so nasty by the staff. And I have never forgiven the Salvation Army since. That was that. And then after six weeks my baby was up for adoption. So when my six weeks were up, she, I had to take her, I had to dress her the day

that she was going, this was the same day as I was going home then. I had to feed her that morning. I had to dress her. I had to wrap her. We were instructed what clothes to bring for them. I had to wrap her in a shawl. I had to carry her down the front stairs, which we weren't normally allowed to use, into the Colonel's office and I wasn't allowed to see the prospective parents. I had to then hand her over to the Colonel and she, and then I had to leave the room. And then she took her and give her to her new family. That was the last I saw her [MN became tearful at this point]. It was extremely difficult to do that. If, if at least they'd had the humility to dress the baby that morning and take her from the nursery it would have been a little bit easier. And this wasn't just me, this was every girl. It was the same, it was the same for everybody. That's what it was. And then being told to then try and live a normal life and pretend that none of this had ever happened. And, as I say, it's only...that was fifty years ago and I would say it's only about two years ago from I was able to tell anyone other than my husband, and my parents who are now dead. I had a younger brother and I don't think he knew. And I hope he didn't. I hope he doesn't know what happened or anything about it. I would be devastated if I thought he knew. And that was, kind of, my experience with Thorndale House and their treatment of us. As I say, it's a long, long, long time ago and for all these years I've put it out of my head and tried not to remember. So there's probably lots of other wee details that I haven't remembered.

OD: Thank you very much for telling me.

MN: I think that's, after that I just had to pick up and get on with it.

OD: And were you, had you left school at that point or did you back to school or...

MN: No, I didn't go back to school. I did go back to the tech and completed a few GCEs⁴. I had left school before I became pregnant. I'd left school to get a job because my father had been made redundant and he was out of work. And I was the eldest in the family and I felt that I needed to leave school to help support and not be a burden on everybody. And then I became pregnant then. So I'd left school sort of around Easter time the year before and I'd got a job. But I could only work until I was starting to show and then I had to leave work before anybody would know. So that...

OD: And did you go back to that job afterwards?

MN: No. No, I had a different job after that.

OD: Do you mind if I ask a couple of questions?

MN: Yeah, go ahead.

OD: But you can tell me if there's anything you don't want to answer.

MN: I'll try and answer everything you ask.

OD: So you were taken by, who dropped you off at Thorndale? Was it your boyfriend's family or your family?

MN: My mother and my boyfriend's father, they dealt with everything.

OD: Right. And you feel that your...

⁴ Tech was technical college.

MN: Daddy, my father, whenever he found out that I was pregnant ... I didn't know I was pregnant. I didn't know how you became pregnant. That seems very strange now.

OD: No, that was my next question.

MN: I didn't know anything about it until I started to faint and then Mummy took me to the doctor and the doctor told her I was pregnant.

OD: He told *her* you were pregnant?

MN: She was with me when I was being examined. She took me in and he told her and I that I was pregnant and...

OD: And when he told you that, what did, did you know what that meant? Did you understand?

MN: Well I knew that I was going to have a baby, but I didn't know any other implications of the whole thing. I wasn't, I wasn't told anything, you know, about anything to do with sex or pregnancy or anything before that. So it was a fairly steep learning curve.

OD: Yeah. Well I mean that's, my next question really is, I think it's really important to understand how women were helped to understand pregnancy after they were told they were pregnant so that we can understand psychologically how prepared you were for things like labour. And I'm guessing that you weren't prepared.

MN: Not at all, not at all.

OD: So did you know, did you know ... Do you think that's maybe why they separated the people who'd had children?

MN: Yes, I think it was. So that the girls who'd had their babies couldn't tell the girls who were pregnant what to expect. As well as that, at some stage during the pregnancy there was a social worker came to the house. Now this must have been to do with the adoption, I presume. And she was actually very nice to me. And she sat down, I can remember, in our front room with Mummy and I. And she told Mummy, and me I suppose, that it was really, really generally it was good girls who became pregnant and bad girls had ways of, knew better ways of avoiding pregnancy. And that was a little bit of a comfort to me in a way because she was the only person who told me that I wasn't bad.

OD: Who wasn't, yeah.

MN: Apart from my father. And Daddy would have supported me and he would have allowed me to come home. My mother wouldn't, didn't.

OD: So was your mother sort of the more dominant one?

MN: Yeah, she would have been in the household, very much so.

OD: And was your house quite like strictly religious, or...

MN: No.

OD: No.

MN: No, not, not really religious at all. We went to church and I was brought up at Sunday school in church, but no we didn't go to church every Sunday and it wasn't a very strict religious regime. My boyfriend's father was, he was more into church, but he was also very much into Faith Mission.⁵

OD: Okay.

MN: And, I like your attitude to that, because that was, that was, it was him was very much the driving force in everything that was happening I think. I think now he organised everything. But he was not the upstanding citizen that he purported to be because he was not averse to interfering with me when he had an opportunity. So, if you want, you can put it like that.

OD: Yeah.

MN: On the pretext that he was sort of explaining to me practically, you know, how not to be touched by men.

OD: So he abused you?

MN: Yeah. But I was, I was... and I believed it. I was...

OD: You were sixteen.

⁵ A Christian evangelical group founded in 1886.

MN: Yeah. Well I was younger, it was before I was pregnant actually, that he did this. And it was a case of, you know, he was really helping me. This was like instruction, you know, to help. And I was persuaded to believe that.

OD: I don't think many teenage girls, I think lots of teenage girls would be in that position as well. I think that's despicable!

MN: Yes, and when I told my cousin recently about the baby, her and I also discussed him and he did the same with them. With her and her sister, when he, if he got, if and when he got an opportunity. So that's, that's Faith Mission. That's the Salvation Army. It's not...

OD: I'm so sorry that happened.

MN: It happened, that was it.

OD: Have you ever told anyone about that or reported that?

MN: No, no, no. And he's now dead. I didn't tell anybody that. So it was nothing to do with the homes, but I was also abused in my younger life by a man who stayed with us, an old man. Well, I thought he was old then, probably now I wouldn't think he was quite so old. He lodged with us for a period of time and he also interfered with me. And now when I watch programmes and see things I realise that I was groomed.

OD: Yeah, absolutely.

MN: Grooming wasn't something I knew anything about.

OD: It sounds like you had a very, well because of these men, had a very warped understanding of what protection was, how men could protect you, you know, all those things. So it sounds...

MN: I believed at the time that they were doing this for my good.

OD: Of course you did, yeah.

MN: And then to become pregnant then was the...

OD: And was, were you pregnant, was your boyfriend, did you understand, like was it consensual or...

MN: Yes.

OD: Yeah.

MN: We were just young and...

OD: Yeah, but maybe you just didn't understand.

MN: We just didn't know any better. Basically that was it.

OD: Which I don't think is a particularly abstract concept.

MN: No, no. No, we just didn't know any better. This was, we got carried away a bit and we didn't realise what the consequences could be. That was...

OD: And he stayed with you the whole time?

MN: Yeah, he did.

OD: Was he allowed to visit you?

MN: Not while I was in there. That was his punishment. And after I came home we stayed together and then we got engaged and then we talked about getting married. And eventually, it's like everything that had happened was just too much for me and I told him I couldn't marry him.

OD: It must have been so hard to be around that family as well and to know ...

MN: After knowing what, you know, how, how little support that I'd had and how, and I blamed his father. And looking back on it now, I suppose, well I blame Mummy as well. And looking back on it now, that was probably right. And, you know, his mother protected, or, not protected... What's the word I'm looking for? She agreed with his father because his father was dominant in that relationship. And Daddy just went along with whatever Mummy wanted to do. He was overruled completely.

OD: Yeah.

MN: And many years later, whenever, after she died, he, him and I talked about this. We never spoke about it. It was never spoke about. After I came home, it was never spoken about. My mother and I never, ever spoke about it afterwards. But after she died, my father and I were always close and he said to me one day, he says "you know MN, whenever you had the baby and wanted to come home", he says "your mummy maybe would have let you come home. Only that * father of boyfriend* wouldn't allow her. He was the baby's grandfather." And

... but Mummy was a strong person and if she had really wanted to allow me to come home, she could have done it I think.

OD: She would have done it.

MN: I think, and in lots of ways I never forgave her for that. We never had words about it. As I say, it was never spoke about. We never had words about it, but somewhere in my subconscious I probably didn't... and she was a good mother in every other way, and after it and before it. And she died from cancer and I nursed her for the last, from, she was diagnosed and she didn't want to go into hospital and I nursed her at home. And I stayed with her twenty-four hours a day, the last two months of her life, until she died. And she never mentioned it to me and I thought she might.

OD: I'm sure she was thinking about it.

MN: I don't know. I slept in the same bed as she did so that if she needed anything during the night I could get it for her and it was never mentioned by her. But that's my story basically I think. I can't think of anything else. And have you any more questions?

OD: Only a few, but only if you're happy to...

MN: Carry on. If I'm not happy to answer them, I'll just not answer them.

OD: So when you were in the home you mentioned a little bit about the girl whose father had raped her. Was there any difference between the way they treated women who'd come in for that reason or women who'd come in for, you know, being with boyfriends?

MN: No, no.

OD: Or were you all treated as if you'd done something wrong?

MN: We were all treated as if we'd done something wrong and she was, even they seemed to be even more harder, even harder on her even though she was so young. And she was ... it wasn't through any fault of her own.

OD: No, but then none of you had done anything wrong. That's...

MN: None of us had, but the rest of us thought we had and we were made to think so. And being marched to the Citadel was very degrading.

OD: What were you wearing? Did they make you wear anything?

MN: No, we just wore ordinary clothes.

OD: Okay.

MN: But we were brought in with the staff in their uniform and their...

OD: So you went to your own place?

MN: And we walked, it was like, you know, walking in like children. If you take primary school children out somewhere and the teachers are with them. It was a similar sort of idea.

OD: And did you have your own space in the church where you all sat?

MN: Yes, where we were all sat together.

OD: And were the staff, when they engaged with you, you know, talk to you or anything, what was their attitude towards you like?

MN: Oh, they were very... just looked down on us.

OD: Cold?

MN: Cold, yes, apart from the one girl that I mentioned and they were very hard and harsh and we were very, very bad. We were evil, we were sinful and we were made to realise that at every opportunity.

OD: And if you were... I know through other people's experience of pregnancy there's a lot of feeling very unwell.

MN: Yes.

OD: Was there any allowances made for that, or were you just expected to...

MN: No, we were just expected to work.

OD: No antenatal, no...

MN: No, no antenatal classes.

OD: Did you have check-ups or...

MN: We, well we did I suppose, we were taken to the maternity unit and showed, I think we were showed where it, you know, where it was and this is where we would be. I don't remember any other antenatal care.

OD: I just, I think... and did you give birth on your own? No family members or anything?

MN: Oh no, no family.

OD: It must have been terrifying.

MN: Just myself. I went into labour during the night.

OD: Did you have pain relief?

MN: We had gas and air. I don't remember having an injection. Just the gas and air's all I can remember.

OD: And how long were you in labour for? Or is that memory just...

MN: I can't...

OD: Of course.

MN: Well I went into labour sometime, we were sent; we went to bed early. So I probably went, my waters probably broke in or around eleven o'clock at night. And I had been, I'd been in pain for a day or two, but didn't really know what it was. And if you were down on your knees scrubbing floors and things you had a

sore back anyway so, you know, it wasn't obvious that that's what was wrong until my water broke. And then I think she was born the next morning.

OD: Okay.

MN: And there was whatever midwives, that whatever number, whatever ones that the Salvation Army had midwifery training.

OD: So you were delivered...

MN: So there was no outside help that I was aware of.

OD: And there was no.... so you were delivered by members of the Salvation Army, which means...

MN: Yes.

OD: Did that cold treatment continue throughout labour or were they nicer to you?

MN: Yes. No, well apart from one girl who was nice to me.

OD: So there was no reassurance or comfort?

MN: No, no.

OD: Or that your pain was normal, or...

MN: No. It was just, you know, this was part of our punishment.

OD: I know, but that's such a vulnerable time. Even if you're thirty it's a vulnerable time.

MN: I know. It was something that we had to... you must remember that we were bad girls and that was made obvious to us at every opportunity.

OD: So I just had one more question then. I'll just check my sheet. You were talking quite a lot about the, kind of, psychological damage that something like that does.

MN: Yes.

OD: You know, the coldness, being told that you're a bad girl, being told that you were evil. Was there anything physical, or was it, were you ever, kind of, mistreated physically, or was it just this horrendous...

MN: Just the work.

OD: The work.

MN: The work. They made us work.

OD: Up to nine months. Well, up to labour.

MN: Aha, and immediately afterwards. The work afterwards was very, very, very hard.

OD: And you haemorrhaged?

MN: And you had to work. I mean they stood there and if you weren't working, or if you felt ill, or somebody tried to help you, if some of the other girls, you know, tried to help. No, it was, you know: "get on with it, you're doing that, you're doing that." Separated – we weren't allowed to talk to each other. The work in that laundry was horrendous, absolutely horrendous. So it was a form of cruelty. You know, we weren't beaten with sticks or anything like that, but we were forced to do such heavy labour.

OD: And it never would have occurred to you to just refuse to do that I'm assuming.

MN: Oh no, because no it wasn't a possibility. No, it wasn't even a possibility to speak. We weren't allowed to speak to each other. So we couldn't speak, you daren't speak back to anybody.

OD: Yeah, and do you think you're, it seems like an obvious question, but do you think your haemorrhage was related to that hard work?

MN: Yes, I think so. Very much so, I think so.

OD: Lots of lifting, lots of hot steam.

MN: Lots of lifting. You were lifting very heavy sheets that were soaked, you know, and they were in water in big vats. And they had to be pulled out and washed and they washed with a washboard, if you know what a washboard is.

OD: Yeah, I do.

MN: And soap and then put through wringers and then they all had to be ironed and folded and whatever too. It was very much like work would have been. It was very much a Victorian laundry. There was nothing in that house that had changed in a hundred years.

OD: And that work's complete ... I mean that work's completely inappropriate for a sixteen-year-old anyway maybe, but for one who'd just given birth.

MN: Yeah.

OD: Okay, I think that's most ... Could I just ask you one final question?

MN: Yeah.

OD: Just a summary question that I ask everyone. And because we've talked about this before, so I'll just say for the tape that you haven't reunited or tracked down your daughter, but that you started to and it was just too painful and there were too many outside influences and we won't go into that, but I'll just record that.

MN: Right.

OD: Who do you think is to blame for what happened to you? Which is what I ask everyone and it's a question that you can think about. But is it your parents? Is it your boyfriend's parents? Is it the state? Is it the religion? Is it...

MN: I think, I think part of it was, a big part of it was probably society at the time.

OD: Yeah.

MN: And then, for what happened to me personally, I blame his father and my mother to a slightly lesser degree. But very much his father. And as years went on, even though I was no longer in that relationship, my parents still knew them and I grew to hate him, basically.

OD: I'm not surprised.

MN: And he died within, about two weeks before my mother died. And I wasn't sorry he was dead. And to be fair, his son was nothing like his father.

OD: No, it doesn't sound like that.

MN: No, he really wasn't.

OD: And I'm glad he was there for you at that time.

MN: And afterwards I cried and cried and cried. And probably, only that it was never diagnosed or whatever, I probably had a nervous breakdown. I couldn't cope with life or anything else for a long time until it was, sort of "well, pull yourself together and get on with it." And I did, but the baby's father was very supportive throughout, as far as he was allowed to be.

OD: Yeah.

MN: And in a lot of ways he wasn't allowed to be. And if we'd been over eighteen we probably would have married then, you know.

OD: And everything might just have been a bit simpler. And they would have had less of an influence I suppose.

MN: Yeah, but we weren't and we weren't allowed to.

OD: And so what would you like to see come out of an inquiry like this? Or, you know, why did you feel that you wanted to contribute?

MN: I felt I wanted to let people know that the Salvation Army is not the organisation that it purports to be. That it was, its members then, and I don't know anything about them now, that its members then were not, they were not Christian. They were not caring. They were in no way sympathetic. They were too, with the exception of possibly one girl, they were sadistic and horrible. There were rules and regulations that didn't need to be. And they were just made as a punishment for us. And to be forced to carry your baby and just hand her over and just walk away was a terribly, terribly hard thing. And I tried to, I made her wee clothes and I had embroidered her initials inside her clothes in the hopes that, if her name was changed she might at least have her initials. And I still have her other clothes today [MN became tearful at this point]. That's fifty years ago and I kept them.

OD: Wow. I'm going to stop the recording there. Thank you, thank you so much. Thank you.

MN: OK.

END OF RECORDING